

The Hybrid Expansion Playbook

Adding an Agentic Product to an Existing Customer Stack

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The most counterintuitive single point in this playbook: the demo is not the conversion moment. The 15 minutes after the demo is.

Who this is for

The post-sales function at any hybrid SaaS company that has just launched or is about to launch an agentic product line. Specifically:

- **CSMs and Account Managers** holding existing customer relationships at hybrid SaaS companies (Salesforce, Intercom, HubSpot, Adobe, ServiceNow, and the next tier down)
- **Heads of Customer Success / VPs of Account Management** designing the playbook for their teams to drive agentic expansion
- **Solutions Engineers and AI Specialists** stepping into existing-customer relationships to drive new-product adoption
- **Founders and operators** at hybrid SaaS companies still figuring out the post-sales motion for their AI line
- **Deployment Strategists** at companies graduating into a meaningful installed base

If you sit in any of those seats and you're responsible for converting existing customers into agentic-product customers, this playbook gives you the operational mechanics — stage by stage — for the four moments that decide whether the expansion lands.

What's in it

Part	Topic
1	Why this scenario deserves its own playbook
2	Stage 1 — Identifying use cases and opportunities
3	Stage 2 — Identifying and bringing in the right stakeholders
4	Stage 3 — The demo-to-action commitment moment
5	Stage 4 — Successfully expanding the account

Part	Topic
6	A consolidated 30 / 60 / 90-day cadence
7	What this implies for content and positioning

How to use this playbook

Three ways:

1. **As an account-planning tool.** Pick one existing customer you've been asked to expand. Walk through Stage 1 (use case identification) using the actual operational data you already have on them. The exercise alone often produces three viable use cases.
2. **As a sales / CS team enablement framework.** The post-demo commitment moment in Stage 3 — the A through G checklist — is something a team can be trained on. It's the single most leveraged 15 minutes in the entire account cycle.
3. **As an org-design reference for hybrid GTM leadership.** The expansion engine in Stage 4 (Land → Prove → Tell → Travel → Expand) is a runnable operating cycle. Companies that operationalize this see compounding account growth.

This is **v1.0**, intentionally focused on the operational mechanics. v1.1 will add named case studies and contributor refinements.

Executive Summary

The most common 2026 reality at hybrid SaaS companies is the third path of AI deployment — an existing customer with an existing per-seat or tiered-license relationship, where the vendor needs to expand them onto a new agentic product line. This has structurally different dynamics than either net-new AI sales or pure greenfield agentic deployment, and almost nothing has been written about it publicly.

Four moments decide whether the expansion lands:

1. **Use case identification** — done by mining the customer's existing data, not by demoing capabilities
2. **Stakeholder mapping** — six distinct roles that are rarely all the same person

3. **Demo-to-action conversion** — the 15 minutes after the demo, with a non-negotiable seven-commitment checklist
4. **Expansion to scale** — the 90-day Land → Prove → Tell → Travel → Expand cycle

Each moment has predictable failure modes and predictable playbook moves. The full mechanics are below.

The most counterintuitive single point: **the demo is not the conversion moment. The 15 minutes after the demo is.** Most CSMs and AMs lose deals here because they treat the demo as the win and don't run the post-demo commitment process. The seven-commitment checklist (A–G) in Stage 3 is the single highest-leverage tool in this playbook.

Part 1: Why This Scenario Deserves Its Own Playbook

The literature on AI deployment in 2026 covers two well-trodden paths:

1. **Net-new AI vendor selling to enterprise customers.** Sierra, Decagon, and Cresta have written about this.
2. **Pure greenfield agentic deployment.** Anthropic's enterprise guide and Palantir's FDE methodology cover this well.

But the most common 2026 reality at companies like Salesforce, Intercom, HubSpot, and Adobe is the **third path**: an existing customer with an existing per-seat or tiered-license relationship, and the vendor needs to expand them onto a new agentic product line. This is the hybrid expansion motion.

It has structurally different dynamics than either of the well-documented paths:

- **You already have a relationship.** That's an advantage *and* a trap. The customer assumes you know everything about their business. You assume they're ready for agentic. Both are wrong.
- **You already have their data.** Massive head start technically. But political baggage too — whoever owns the data inside their company is now in the conversation.
- **You already have stakeholders.** And they may not be the right ones for the agentic motion. The champion who bought your SaaS license may not be the buyer for the AI agent.
- **You already have a price point.** And introducing outcome-based or consumption pricing on top of an existing subscription requires real commercial design.

The four moments — use-case identification, stakeholder bring-in, demo-to-action conversion, expansion to scale — map directly to the four stages of this motion. Each one breaks differently than at a net-new deployment.

Part 2: Stage 1 — Identifying Use Cases and Opportunities

The default that fails

The most common failure: the CSM/AM runs a demo of the agentic product, then asks the customer *"where could you use this?"* The customer says "let me think about it" and the conversation dies. The vendor never gets the discovery they need.

This fails because:

- The customer doesn't yet think in agentic terms
- The CSM/AM isn't trained to translate operational pain into agentic capability
- "Where could you use this?" puts the burden on the customer to do the vendor's job

The reframe that works

Don't start with the AI capability. Start with the customer's existing operational data. You already have it. The opportunities are sitting inside your platform.

For a knowledge management or content product: every repeated search query, every workflow where users escalate to a human, every report that gets manually generated quarterly — these are agentic candidates. *You can see them in the data already.*

For a CRM or sales product: every deal where a human played a coordination role that could be automated, every QBR preparation cycle, every renewal review.

For a marketing or automation product: every campaign decision point that's currently manual, every personalization that's rule-based.

A use-case identification framework

Three lenses to scan a customer for opportunities:

Lens 1 — Workflow archaeology. Pick one high-volume workflow they currently run on your platform. Trace it end-to-end. Identify steps that are:

- High-volume (more than 100 instances per month)
- Decision-light (the right answer is in the data, not in judgment)
- Currently manual or rule-based
- Variable in quality across performers

Those are agentic candidates.

Lens 2 — Adjacent department friction. Where does information flow from your platform's primary users to *other* teams? Those handoffs are often agentic opportunities. Examples: support to product (issue summarization), sales to CS (handoff intel), CS to finance (renewal forecasting).

Lens 3 — Strategic exec asks. What did the customer's leadership ask them to do this year that they're behind on? Often: "scale without hiring," "reduce time to insight," "improve compliance." Map those asks back to your agentic product's capabilities.

What the discovery conversation actually sounds like

Not: *"Want to see a demo of our new AI agent?"*

Instead, a structured 45-minute conversation:

1. **(10 min)** "Walk me through your highest-volume workflow on our platform today."
2. **(10 min)** "Where in that workflow are people spending time on work that follows a pattern?"
3. **(10 min)** "What does your team's leadership want you to do this year that you haven't gotten to?"
4. **(10 min)** "Who else in the company touches the output of this workflow?"
5. **(5 min)** "Let me come back next week with three specific automation candidates and what the expected ROI would look like."

The week-later return — with **three specific candidates and rough ROI math** — is the move that converts. The customer cannot do this analysis themselves. You bring real proposals, not capability demos.

Use-case priority matrix

Score candidates on impact and ease of deployment:

	Easy to deploy	Hard to deploy
High impact	START HERE — 90-day pilot	Strategic build — 6-month investment
Low impact	Quick win — but don't lead with this	Drop

Always start in the top-left quadrant. Quick wins build the political capital and case-study credibility you need to expand into the other quadrants.

Part 3: Stage 2 — Stakeholder Mapping and Right-Room Construction

The trap of relationship inertia

Because you already have a customer relationship, the natural instinct is to work through the existing contacts. **This is almost always wrong for agentic expansion.**

The original buyer for your SaaS may be:

- The wrong economic level (your SaaS was a tactical buy; agentic is strategic)
- The wrong functional area (your SaaS was for one team; the agentic use case spans many)
- Personally threatened (the agent automates work their team currently does)
- Out of pocket (your contact moved roles; you didn't notice)

You have to **map fresh** for the agentic motion. The original relationships are *useful* — for warm intros — but rarely the right room for the decision.

The stakeholder map for agentic expansion

Six roles need to be identified, and they're rarely all the same person:

Role	What they own	Why they matter for AI
Original Champion	Existing product relationship; cares about <i>your</i> success	Warm intro engine; political cover
Workflow Owner	The team doing the work the agent will automate	Decisive vote on whether the use case lands
AI Owner	Customer's AI strategy (often new in 2026 — CAIO, AI Steering Committee chair)	Strategic priority; budget unlock
Data Owner	The data the agent needs (often Engineering / IT, not the SaaS owner)	Technical green light; integration approval
Compliance / Legal	Regulatory exposure; data governance	Hard block if not engaged early
Economic Buyer	Discretionary budget at the level the agentic deal requires	Final commercial approval

At a Fortune 500 customer in 2026, these are often **six different people in three different departments**. Your existing champion knows maybe two of them well.

Bringing them in — without breaking the existing relationship

The political problem: walking past your champion to introduce yourself directly to their CIO or AI Steering Committee will damage the existing relationship and sometimes the deal.

The play that works:

1. **Ask the champion to map their org for you, explicitly.** "I want to make sure we bring the right people to the AI conversation. Who would I need at the table for this kind of initiative?" Most champions respond well to this — they like being treated as the senior advisor.
2. **Offer to make the champion look good.** "If we run this discovery right, you'll have a business case ready when your boss asks 'what are we doing about AI?'" This turns the expansion into a *political win* for the champion.
3. **Let the champion drive the first meeting with each new stakeholder.** Even if you do most of the talking, the champion makes the intro. This preserves the relationship.

4. **Bring vendor seniority to match customer seniority.** If you're trying to engage their AI Steering Committee, send your VP of Customer Success or your CTO — not just the CSM. Customers read seniority signal.

The Compliance / Legal early-engagement move

For agentic deals in 2026, Compliance and Legal are often the silent killer. EU AI Act, SOC 2 attestation requirements, data residency, model versioning audit trail, customer data flowing into training (no? confirm in writing).

The play: **engage Compliance in the second or third meeting, not the eighth.** Most CSMs avoid this because Compliance is "scary." But the longer they're absent, the longer their concerns fester. Bring them in early, treat them as a partner, give them clean documentation upfront.

If your company has good AI compliance posture (SOC 2, EU AI Act compliance, no-training-on-customer-data clauses), this becomes a competitive advantage. If you don't, you find out about it before you've burned the deal.

Part 4: Stage 3 — The Demo-to-Action Commitment Moment

Why most agentic demos die

The classic failure pattern: brilliant demo. Customer is excited. "This is amazing." Champion says "let me take this internal." Three weeks pass. Nothing happens. Six weeks pass. The champion is "busy." Three months pass. The deal is dead.

This happens because:

1. The demo created **emotional energy** but no **operational plan**
2. The customer doesn't yet know how to operationalize this internally
3. No specific next steps were named in the room
4. No specific owner was named on the customer side
5. No measurable baseline was captured
6. No commitment to a next meeting

The CSM/AM thinks the demo was the conversion moment. It wasn't. **The 15 minutes immediately after the demo is where the deal is won or lost.**

The post-demo commitment framework — the A–G checklist

Before leaving the demo room (or video call), the following must happen — explicitly, on the record, in writing:

	Commitment	What it secures
A	Named customer-side owner	Specific person responsible day-to-day
B	Agreed scope for a 30-day POV	One or two specific use cases
C	Success criteria	Measurable, in the customer's own language
D	Baseline numbers captured	So ROI is defensible at the end
E	Stakeholders for next meeting	Specific names plus roles
F	Three meetings scheduled	In calendars before leaving the room
G	Business case framework	Champion takes a one-pager internally

If any of A–G doesn't happen, **you don't have a deal.** You have a hopeful conversation that will die.

The specific language to use

Each commitment needs to be asked for *explicitly*. Examples:

A — Owner: *"Who on your team would be the day-to-day owner for this if we moved forward? I want to make sure we're aligned with the right person."*

B — Scope: *"Of the use cases we discussed, which two would you want to pilot first? Let's name them now so I can come back with a real plan, not a generic proposal."*

C — Success criteria: *"In 90 days, what would have to be true for you to call this pilot successful? Specifically — what number, who agrees on it, how do we measure it?"*

D — Baseline: *"What's the current state of those numbers today? Even a rough estimate. If you can pull the actual data, I can prep a sharper ROI for our next meeting."*

E — Stakeholders: *"Beyond you, who would need to be in the room before we sign a POV? Let's name them now."*

F — Meetings: *"Let me pull up your calendar and lock in the next three working sessions. Standing time, even if we don't fill them, will keep momentum."*

G — Internal case: *"Before we end — can I sketch out a one-page business case you can take to your VP? It'll save you the work of writing it yourself."*

Why this works

Each ask is **small, specific, and benefits the champion**. They're not committing to a deal — they're naming an owner, scoping a pilot, securing meetings. Each step compounds. By the time you've done A–G in the same conversation, you have a real operational plan, and the champion has the internal artifacts they need to defend the project.

The CSMs and DSs who reliably convert demos to deals have **internalized this checklist**. They run it without making it feel like a checklist. They're persistent on every one.

The "demo-to-action escape velocity" rule

If you can't get four of the seven commitments (A–G) in the post-demo window, the deal is unlikely to convert. **Don't fool yourself**. Either run the meeting again with the right people, or downgrade the deal in your forecast.

This is hard advice for CSMs trained on hope. Healthier to call the deal dead and re-engage cleanly than to slow-walk it for six months.

Part 5: Stage 4 — Successfully Expanding the Account

The expansion economics are weird for hybrid

In B2B SaaS, expansion was usually seat expansion or module addition. With agentic products layered on a SaaS base, expansion gets structurally messier:

- **Two pricing models in one account.** Per-seat for the SaaS, outcome-based for the agent. Procurement sometimes can't handle this; deals stall.
- **Different renewal timing.** SaaS often multi-year; AI agent contracts often one-year max. Customer's renewal calendar gets fragmented.
- **Different budget pools.** SaaS often comes from IT or operations budget; AI budget often comes from a CAIO discretionary fund or innovation budget.
- **Different decision velocity.** SaaS renewal is a known process. AI agent expansion is a strategic conversation each time.

Successful hybrid expansion engineers around these tensions, not against them.

The four expansion patterns

Pattern	Move	Difficulty
Workflow expansion	Same team, more use cases	Easiest. Same buying center, same data, same trust.
Complexity expansion	Deflection → revenue-generating	High value, requires trust. Customer must believe the agent is reliable before letting it touch revenue.
Department expansion	New team, similar use case	Hardest. Different stakeholders, different success criteria, different procurement.
Geographic expansion	Rollout to international offices	Medium. Same buying center, but legal and compliance multiply.

The expansion sequence that works: **Workflow** → **Complexity** → **Department** → **Geographic**. Workflow expansion proves the operating model. Complexity expansion grows the ACV. Department expansion grows the political footprint. Geographic expansion is the last step.

The 90-day proof cycle as the expansion engine

Every successful agentic expansion at a hybrid SaaS company runs on the same engine:

Land → Prove → Tell → Travel → Expand

- **Land** — 90-day initial pilot
- **Prove** — measurable ROI documented
- **Tell** — internal case study written
- **Travel** — case study sent to other departments
- **Expand** — second use case scoped

The cycle is 90 days end-to-end. **Three cycles in a year = three expansions** = ACV growth that compounds.

The key insight: **the "Tell" step is where most CSMs and DSs drop the ball**. They prove ROI internally, then assume the customer will distribute the case study. Customers almost never do. The vendor needs to actively help the champion write and circulate the internal case study. This is uncomfortable for traditional CS people but it's the highest-leverage activity in expansion.

Specific tactics that work

- **Quarterly executive readouts**, not just operational reviews. Get in front of the customer's CIO or CAIO every quarter with delivered outcomes. Builds the case for adjacent expansion.
- **Internal champion development**. Convert the original workflow owner into an internal evangelist by giving them speaking slots at the customer's all-hands, or a byline on a case study they helped write.
- **Time expansions to budget cycles**. Don't propose new spend in Q4 if the customer is in a freeze. Don't propose in early Q1 if budgets aren't finalized. Mid-Q2 and early Q3 are usually the windows.
- **Bundle the renewal conversation with expansion**. When you renew, you're already in the procurement room. Use that opening to introduce the next module.
- **Customer Advisory Board membership**. The high-value strategic customer should be invited into your CAB. It deepens the relationship, makes them feel like an insider, generates inbound expansion

conversations.

Common failure modes in expansion

1. **"Set-it-and-forget-it after go-live."** Land the first use case, drop the relationship to maintenance, never come back to expand. Most common failure.
 2. **Pushing for expansion before ROI is proven.** Champion can't internally justify the next purchase. Looks like you're more interested in revenue than their success.
 3. **Cross-departmental expansion without re-mapping stakeholders.** Assumes the original champion can sell into adjacent departments. Almost never works.
 4. **Pricing model mismatch.** Offering per-seat expansion when the use case is outcome-shaped (or vice versa). Customer can't process.
 5. **Expansion right before the renewal cliff.** Customer feels gun-to-head pressure. Damages trust. Better to renew, breathe, then expand 90 days later.
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Part 6: A Consolidated 30 / 60 / 90-Day Cadence

If a CSM or DS at a hybrid SaaS company is given an existing customer to expand into the agentic product, here's a realistic cadence:

Day	Activity	Output
0	Internal account review with sales / support / CS history	Map of existing relationships, account health, friction points
1–7	Discovery conversation with existing champion	3 candidate use cases with rough impact estimates
8–14	Stakeholder mapping; intro to AI Owner and Workflow Owner	6-role map populated; first new stakeholder meeting scheduled
15–21	Demo with broader stakeholder group	Post-demo commitment moment (A–G in writing)

Day	Activity	Output
22–30	POV / pilot scope agreed; legal and compliance engaged	Signed pilot SOW; named owner; agreed success criteria
31–60	Pilot deployment (Build and Eval phase)	Working integration; eval running
61–90	Pilot operates; outcomes measured; first review	M3 outcome report; written internal case study draft
90	Joint exec review of pilot results	Decision: expand to next use case (Workflow → Complexity → Department → Geographic)

Three discrete expansion cycles like this in 12 months — the account typically doubles or triples in size at a hybrid SaaS company.

Part 7: What This Implies for Content and Positioning

This process — the four moments — is a substantial content cluster in its own right. Each stage is publishable as a field note. Sequence:

1. *How to identify agentic use cases inside an existing customer's data — without a demo.*
2. *The six-role stakeholder map for agentic expansion at a hybrid SaaS customer.*
3. *The 15 minutes after the demo: how the deal actually gets won.*
4. *The 90-day expansion engine: Land → Prove → Tell → Travel → Expand.*

Each of these is missing publicly. Salesforce, Intercom, and Adobe all publish *that* they're doing the hybrid motion. None of them publishes *how to run the post-sales motion that makes it work*. That's the gap this playbook is the first attempt to close.

About this playbook

Author: Fikret Alimov. Operator's-seat field notes from inside the transition this document describes — written from active practice in hybrid SaaS post-sales, not from outside it.

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Contact and pushback: This is v1.0 — operational mechanics with intentionally light case-study content. If you've run this motion at a hybrid SaaS company and have named examples, refinements, or corrections, please reach out. v1.1 will incorporate contributor input.

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Versioning

- **v1.0 (May 2026)** — Initial publication. Covers the four moments of the hybrid expansion motion, with frameworks, conversation language, and the 30 / 60 / 90-day cadence.

Planned for v1.1

- Named case studies from practitioners at Salesforce, Intercom, ServiceNow, Adobe
- Expanded section on the AI Specialist overlay role mid-transition
- Templates for the post-demo commitment moment (printable, shareable artifact)
- Expanded section on procurement-side mechanics for mixed pricing models

Sources

This document synthesizes patterns from:

- Salesforce's published Agentforce Customer Zero post and Contact Center 100 program description
- Intercom's 2026 Customer Service Transformation Report and *Inside the AI-First Support Team*
- Adobe's announced outcome-based pricing for CX Enterprise
- Anthropic's Enterprise AI Transformation Guide (three-step framework)

- Palantir's Foundry Program Overview (CoE handoff)
- a16z's "Retention Is All You Need" (M3 retention framework)

Where specific tactics are named, they're either drawn from public sources or marked as operating recommendations.

End of v1.0. Published 2026-05-26.